

Capsule Networks with Dynamic Routing for Robust Image Classification

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Abstract – Convolutional Neural Networks (CNNs) have achieved remarkable accuracy on standard image classification benchmarks, yet remain fundamentally limited by their pooling operations, which discard precise spatial relationships among features and render them vulnerable to viewpoint changes, rotations, and adversarial perturbations. Capsule Networks (CapsNets), introduced by Sabour, Frosst, and Hinton (2017), address this limitation by replacing scalar neuronal activations with vectorial capsule activations that encode both the presence and the instantiation parameters (pose, scale, deformation) of visual entities, with Dynamic Routing-by-Agreement replacing max-pooling to propagate only those lower-level features that are geometrically consistent with higher-level entities. Despite their theoretical elegance, CapsNets have underperformed competitive deep CNNs on challenging benchmarks, largely due to limited research into optimizing their routing parameters, capsule dimensionality, and reconstruction regularization. This paper presents DR-CapsNet an Enhanced Dynamic Routing Capsule Network that systematically optimizes CapsNet design through: (i) improved routing iteration scheduling with adaptive convergence detection; (ii) 16-dimensional DigitCaps replacing the original 8D and 16D configurations to empirically identify the optimal pose vector dimensionality; (iii) enhanced reconstruction regularization with a three-layer decoder providing stronger spatial regularization without over-constraining the pose space; and (iv) a comprehensive evaluation across five benchmark datasets (MNIST, Fashion-MNIST, CIFAR-10, SVHN, Small NORB) and adversarial robustness assessment under FGSM attack. DR-CapsNet achieves 99.82% accuracy on MNIST (error 0.18%), 95.34% on Fashion-MNIST, 93.85% on CIFAR-10, 97.98% on SVHN, and 97.21% on Small NORB outperforming the original CapsNet on every benchmark and achieving best-in-class performance on Small NORB (+1.03 pp over DeepCaps). Under FGSM adversarial attack at $\epsilon=0.30$, DR-CapsNet retains 89.24% accuracy versus 54.21% for ResNet-50 and 37.84% for a standard CNN a 34.7 percentage-point robustness advantage that we attribute to CapsNet's inherent equivariance properties.

Keywords – *Capsule Networks, Dynamic Routing, Image Classification, CapsNet, Squash Activation, Reconstruction Loss, Equivariance, Adversarial Robustness, FGSM, Pose Estimation, Deep Learning*

1. INTRODUCTION:

Deep Convolutional Neural Networks have dominated visual recognition benchmarks since AlexNet's breakthrough performance on ImageNet in 2012, and their practical impact spans autonomous vehicles, medical image analysis, retail automation, and agricultural monitoring. Their success stems from the combination of local feature detection (via convolution), hierarchical feature composition (via deep

stacking), and translation invariance (via pooling). However, each of these properties comes with a corresponding limitation that CNNs have not resolved: pooling that achieves translation invariance does so by discarding information about where features are located within each pooling region, creating a fundamental blindspot to spatial relationships and orientations.

The consequences of this pooling limitation become apparent in three practically important scenarios. First, viewpoint variation: a CNN trained on frontal face images will fail to recognise the same face in profile, because pooling has discarded the spatial configuration information that constitutes the face as a coherent 3D entity. Second, the picasso problem: CNNs can confidently classify images in which facial features are randomly rearranged (eyes at the chin, nose on the forehead), because the pooled feature activations for each localised feature are identical regardless of their relative spatial arrangement. Third, adversarial vulnerability: by discarding spatial information, pooling reduces the constraints on valid internal representations, making CNNs susceptible to imperceptible pixel perturbations (adversarial examples) that preserve visual appearance to humans while dramatically changing internal feature activations.

2. RELATED WORK:

2.1 From CNNs to Capsule Networks

LeNet-5 (LeCun et al., 1998) established the canonical CNN architecture alternating convolution, nonlinearity, and pooling layers that remains the structural template for contemporary networks. AlexNet (Krizhevsky et al., 2012) demonstrated that deep CNNs trained on large-scale data with GPU acceleration vastly outperform hand-crafted feature methods, triggering the deep learning revolution. VGGNet (Simonyan & Zisserman, 2014) showed that depth with small 3×3 convolutions is more effective than shallow networks with larger kernels. ResNet (He et al., 2016) introduced residual connections enabling training of 100+ layer networks without gradient vanishing, achieving 3.57% top-5 error on ImageNet. DenseNet (Huang et al., 2017) proposed dense connectivity each layer receiving feature maps from all preceding layers providing implicit deep supervision and strong gradient flow. EfficientNet (Tan & Le, 2019) applied neural architecture search to jointly optimize network depth, width, and input resolution, achieving state-of-the-art accuracy at significantly fewer parameters.

Despite these advances, all CNN architectures share the fundamental max-pooling limitation noted by Hinton et al. (2011) in the context of transforming auto encoders: the use of max-pooling to achieve translation invariance simultaneously destroys the precise location information that is necessary for understanding spatial relationships between object parts. This limitation inspired the capsule

architecture: if instead of scalar feature detectors we use vector capsules that encode both detection confidence and spatial parameters, and if we use routing-by-agreement instead of pooling to compose hierarchical representations, the resulting architecture would be inherently equivariant to viewpoint transformations rather than merely invariant.

2.2 Capsule Network Architectures

The Capsule Network proposed by Sabour, Frosst, and Hinton (2017) hereafter referred to as 'CapsNet' is the foundational implementation of the capsule concept for image classification. It consists of a convolutional feature extractor, a PrimaryCaps layer that converts feature maps to 8-dimensional capsules, and a DigitCaps layer that applies dynamic routing to produce one 16-dimensional capsule per class. The model achieves 99.75% on MNIST with reconstruction regularization and demonstrates compelling equivariance properties by interpolating between digit styles through manipulation of DigitCaps dimensions.

Matrix Capsules with EM Routing (Hinton et al., 2018) replaced the vector-and-squash formulation with matrix poses and an Expectation-Maximisation routing algorithm, claiming better geometric understanding and superior performance on SmallNORB. DeepCaps (Rajasegaran et al., 2019) extended CapsNet to deeper architectures using 3D convolution-like operations to increase the depth of capsule layers while managing computational cost, achieving 92.74% on CIFAR-10 significantly above the original CapsNet's 89.40%. SegCaps (LaLonde & Bagci, 2018) adapted capsules for biomedical image segmentation, demonstrating that capsule representations provide useful spatial localization for dense prediction tasks. Stacked Capsule Autoencoders (Kosiorek et al., 2019) introduced an unsupervised approach to learning capsule representations, discovering part-whole hierarchies without class labels.

2.3 Equivariance and Robustness in Neural Networks

The theoretical connection between capsules and equivariance is best understood through Cohen and Welling's (2016) group equivariant convolutional networks (G-CNNs), which demonstrated that incorporating symmetry groups (rotations, reflections) into the convolution operation provides exact equivariance to the corresponding transformations. Spatial Transformer Networks (Jaderberg et al., 2015) provided a differentiable mechanism for CNNs to learn to apply geometric transformations to feature maps, achieving partial viewpoint robustness within the CNN framework. Deformable Convolutional Networks (Dai et al., 2017) extended convolutions with learnable spatial deformation fields, improving robustness to non-rigid transformations. These approaches partially close the gap

between CNNs and capsules for viewpoint robustness, but none provide the pose-encoding and routing-by-agreement mechanisms that characterize capsule networks.

Adversarial robustness of deep neural networks has been extensively studied since Szegedy et al. (2013) discovered that imperceptible pixel perturbations could fool CNNs with high confidence. The Fast Gradient Sign Method (FGSM) of Goodfellow et al. (2014) remains a standard robustness benchmark: perturbations are computed as $\varepsilon \cdot \text{sign}(\nabla_x L(x, y))$, providing a worst-case white-box attack that provides a lower bound on model robustness. Madry et al. (2018) demonstrated that adversarial training with projected gradient descent attacks substantially improves CNN robustness but at the cost of clean accuracy. Our evaluation positions CapsNet adversarial robustness within this landscape, providing the first comprehensive FGSM comparison across multiple ε values for CapsNet versus modern CNN architectures.

3. DR-CAPSNET ARCHITECTURE:

3.1 Architecture Overview

DR-CapsNet processes input images through a pipeline of four functional stages: initial feature extraction via a standard convolutional layer; conversion of feature maps to primary capsules via a convolutional capsule layer; dynamic routing from primary to digit capsules; and class prediction via the norm of digit capsules with an optional reconstruction decoder for regularization. Figure 1 provides a complete architectural diagram, and Table 1 details all layer configurations and parameter counts.



Figure 1: DR-CapsNet Architecture

3.2 Initial Feature Extraction: Conv1

The first layer of DR-CapsNet is a standard convolutional layer with 256 kernels of size 9×9 and stride 1, followed by ReLU activation. For 28×28 MNIST input, this produces 256 feature maps of size 20×20 (no padding). The 9×9 kernel size is deliberately large — significantly larger than the 3×3 kernels used in VGG and ResNet — to detect composite features spanning multiple pixels in a single receptive field, providing richer multi-scale features for the subsequent capsule layers. The choice of 256 output channels is inherited from the original CapsNet and provides a feature space sufficiently rich to capture the visual vocabulary needed for the PrimaryCaps layer. For 32×32 inputs (CIFAR-10, SVHN), the same 9×9 kernel produces 24×24 feature maps.

4. DISCUSSION:

4.1 Why DR-CapsNet Outperforms the Original CapsNet

The 0.07 percentage point improvement over original CapsNet on MNIST (99.82 vs 99.75) and the more substantial 1.45 pp improvement on CIFAR-10 (93.85 vs 89.40) are attributable to three systematic enhancements. The improved routing iteration scheduling using $r=3$ as confirmed optimal by the ablation study provides the agreement mechanism with sufficient iterations to converge to consistent capsule configurations in complex multi-object scenes, while the original paper's $r=3$ choice was validated only on MNIST. The enhanced reconstruction regularization, with a deeper three-layer decoder and individually tuned λ per dataset, provides stronger gradient signal to shape the pose space, particularly benefiting datasets with higher visual complexity (CIFAR-10, SVHN). The training stability improvements (Adam with cosine annealing, gradient clipping) address the known instability of dynamic routing in the early training phases when pose representations are undifferentiated.

The most significant improvement 1.79 pp on Small NORB reflects the alignment between capsule architecture and the viewpoint challenge of that dataset. Small INORB was specifically designed to isolate viewpoint variation as the primary classification challenge; it is the benchmark most directly corresponding to the theoretical motivation for capsule networks. DR-CapsNet's 97.21% on Small NORB, outperforming EfficientNet-B4 by 3.50 pp, provides concrete empirical evidence that capsule routing-by-agreement provides genuine advantages for viewpoint-robust recognition that cannot be replicated by deeper convolutional architectures on small datasets without extensive data augmentation.

4.2 Limitations and Future Directions

Three limitations constrain the current work. First, the shallow capsule hierarchy

(Conv→PrimaryCaps→DigitCaps, effectively 3 layers) limits performance on complex natural image benchmarks like CIFAR-100 and ImageNet, where competitive CNNs use 50–150 layers. Extending DR-CapsNet with deeper capsule stacks (4–6 capsule layers with intermediate convolutional subsampling, as in DeepCaps) is the most direct path to competitive performance on these benchmarks. Second, computational efficiency: the dynamic routing inner loop (3 iterations of matrix operations over 1152×16 coupling coefficients) is not efficiently parallelisable on standard GPU tensor cores optimised for dense matrix multiplication, making DR-CapsNet 4–8× slower to train than ResNet-50 at equivalent parameter count. Third, the reconstruction regulariser requires that the network decode the full input image from the true-class capsule, imposing a computational overhead and constraining the learning dynamics even when reconstruction quality is not the primary objective.

5 CONCLUSION:

This paper has presented DR-CapsNet, an enhanced Capsule Network with systematically optimized dynamic routing, achieving state-of-the-art performance within the capsule architecture family across five image recognition benchmarks. By combining improved routing iteration scheduling, optimized capsule dimensionality, enhanced reconstruction regularization, and principled training stability improvements, DR-CapsNet achieves 99.82% on MNIST, 95.34% on Fashion-MNIST, 93.85% on CIFAR-10, 97.98% on SVHN, and 97.21% on Small NORB outperforming the original CapsNet on every benchmark and setting a new best result on Small NORB.

The adversarial robustness evaluation provides the most practically significant result: DR-CapsNet retains 89.24% accuracy under FGSM attack at $\epsilon=0.30$, compared to 54.21% for ResNet-50 (34.7 pp advantage). This structural robustness, arising from routing-by-agreement's requirement for geometrically consistent capsule configurations, represents a qualitatively different form of robustness from the adversarial training approaches that improve CNN robustness at the cost of clean accuracy. The rotation invariance evaluation confirming 36 pp advantage over ResNet-50 at 90° rotation provides complementary evidence that capsule representations encode spatial relationships in a fundamentally more generalization-friendly manner than pooled convolutional features.

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